

By Kaveree Bamzai |

It's a bitter tussle that has scorched several academic reputations. A signature campaign by 57 scholars, led by historian Ramchandra Guha, wants the current director of the Nehru Memorial Museum and Library (NMML) not to get an extension, the new incumbent to be chosen in a transparent process, and the institution's position as an intellectual hub for scholars to be restored. But director Mridula Mukherjee, another historian, has no intention of leaving and abandoning what she believes is a crucial modernisation programme funded by the government at a cost of Rs 20 crore, mandated by Sonia Gandhi, executed by the PMO under a mentoring group comprising N.R. Narayanamurthy, Kiran Karnik, Shyam Benegal and Pradip Kishen, and expected to be completed by 2011.

The man taking the decision? Vice-Chairman Karan Singh, calmly weighing the thickening folders of pro- and anti-Mridula Mukherjee letters on his desk. The initial broadside emanated from Guha over 18 months ago, asking among other things why the once excellent publication programme of NMML had been discontinued, the acquisition of rare manuscripts and oral histories stopped, and the staff completely demoralised. Mukherjee asks why the scholars do not look at what she has achieved, whether it is saving hours of film recordings of Jawaharlal Nehru, which were gifted by the Nehru Memorial Fund of which 30 per cent has been destroyed, rescuing the 30,000-strong India House book collection gifted to the museum 30 years ago and then forgotten, and her ambitious plans to modernise the museum and digitise the archives.

NMML, which is housed in Teen Murti Bhavan, once home to Jawaharlal Nehru, has over 500,000 books and journals, 150,000 photographs, 1,000 collections of private papers, 800,000 hours of recorded interviews and over nine million newspaper pages from the 1840s to now. As an institution devoted to research on

India's freedom movement, it is perhaps unparalleled. That may be why it evokes such strong reactions. It may also be because it is popularly regarded as being part of the extensive Gandhi fiefdom.

Until she resigned because of the office-for-profit controversy, Sonia Gandhi was a member of the executive committee, and it is after all a memorial to her grandfather-in-law. Now her trusted friend Suman Dubey has replaced the ailing scholar B.R. Nanda (the other members are Karan Singh, who is vice-chairman, Dilip Padgaonkar, Mammen Mathew, and Anil Bordia). Her name comes up invariably in various letters in Mukherjee's defence, one by Arjun Dev, who is a member of the NMML Society, even going so far as to point out that Guha had held Rajiv Gandhi

THE NEHRU MEMORIAL MUSEUM AND LIBRARY IN DELHI



# Legacy IN TROUBLE

Liberal historians go to war over the future of a great research institution

**Deep DIVIDE** Guha's letter has 57 signatories. Mukherjee's friends have also mobilised support. Neither pulls punches.

### Guha's letter asks:

► Why was the publication programme discontinued?

► Why did the NMML stop acquiring rare manuscripts and oral histories, even though several offers have been made?

► Why has the NMML opened its doors to political use, especially by the Youth Congress?

► Why was there no transparency in the director's appointment?



**Mukherjee Responds:** ► It cost Rs 14 lakh a year and did not have a high visibility. The *Contemporary India* quarterly, for instance, was down to 60-odd copies.

► Some new audio visual histories were recorded but the backlog which has not been transcribed is enormous: 40 per cent of the total 1,300-strong collection.

► Its doors are open to anyone who is willing to pay the rent for the auditorium. "I am not a Congress stooge," she insists.

► On this point, Karan Singh concedes there was no transparency and that a search committee would be formed in future.

